



theWindow

THE NEWSLETTER OF CHRIST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH, NEW HAVEN. VOLUME 2, ISSUE 2. SPRING 2000.

A Preliminary Thumbs Up

BY PRESTON GRAHAM



from the Pastor

Recently, after an amazing flurry of last minute work and conversations with our neighbors, meetings with our lawyers, city planners, and our alderman (who has been very supportive of our project), we were given the first official "thumbs up" from the city of New Haven regarding the establishment of our denomination in this great city.

Below is the text that I delivered to the city planning commission, which I think pretty much sums up what's going on here. We need to remain in devoted prayer that the forces of evil that are working against the building of the kingdom of God will not prevail. There is still much to be done politically in order for this project to come to fruition. I am more deeply aware than ever that we are doing something very special here for the future of the gospel in New Haven. We are not merely a church, but a church planting movement, and we desperately need a hub to further our Reformational vision concerning the gospel of grace! Please take ownership of this vision through your prayers!

Text of the prepared statement delivered on March 15 to the city of New Haven planning commission:

Madam Chairwoman:

When we purchased this property several years ago, our mindset focused on what seemed to us to be a "commercial" piece of property consisting of a rundown historical cottage and a portion of undeveloped land situated in a downtown location just perfect for a church

such as ours. Because Whitney Avenue is the address of the property, we viewed the property in relation to the Whitney corridor. In this vein, we measured our project against such places as the New Haven Colony Historical Society across the street, the Yale offices next door, the Peabody Museum, etc. As we saw it at the time, our development plans seemed modest in comparison and were well within the kinds of development that had already occurred all up and down Whitney. In addition, we believed that our plans were compatible with the mix of office and residential property on Bradley Street. In short, prior to our acquisition of the property, we never anticipated the concerns that

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were articulated when we revealed our original plans for a 400 seat sanctuary several years back. Again, we were thinking about our property in relation the existing businesses and institutions on Whitney Avenue.

I hope that the city plan commission can appreciate that, while we might not have anticipated the issues and concerns raised by the neighborhood when we first arrived on Whitney Avenue, we never acted out of indifference. In truth, when we proposed our first set of plans asking for an exception to the parking ordinance several years ago, we were honestly stunned by the depth of feeling raised by many ('Thumbs Up' continued on page 2)

Building Plans

BY DEXTER CHEN



Perspectives

Recently I was asked to contribute something to the Window regarding my involvement with the church building project. I accepted, and since then I've had time to reflect on all that has happened in the last few weeks and months and even years to put things into perspective. For many of you who are new to Christ Presbyterian Church and don't know Mary Li and me, we first started attending worship at CPC when the church was meet-

ing in the music room at Amity Junior High School out on Route 34. Mary and I were newlyweds relocating from New York City where we both had spent many years as part of our respective communities. I was in the midst of a ten year part-time endeavor to assist my former church in their building project (I am a registered architect) when Mary accepted a position in the Dean's Office at Yale. I followed her here believing that God was calling us to this community. The architectural profession was suffering through its worst depression since the '70s, but I was able to find modest employment, first in Naugatuck and then here in New ('Building Plans' continued on page 3)

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The Littlest Learners

BY FRAN ONOFRIO



When we were holding church services at the Neighborhood Music School, Preston approached me and asked if I would consider teaching the two and three year old Sunday School class. Although I had no experience with this sort of thing, Preston encouraged me to give it a try. That was five years ago, and I'm still at it.

Our class begins every Sunday when I pick up the children from the nursery. They always greet with a great deal of excitement about starting the lesson. We do a number of activities, and they vary from week to week. The activities include creative play with Playdough, art projects, reading books, snack time, games and songs, Bible story time, sharing, and praying, all of which are related to the week's lesson. Although my goals are to teach them how to share, take turns, and show patience, kindness, and Jesus' love for everyone, they continue to surprise me with how well they listen to directions and retain information. Each child is different and, as you can imagine, some of

the things they come up with to say are very humorous. It's also astounding how much growth takes place from the time they start the class at two years to when they go to the next age level class at four years old. The improvement in communication skills, motor skills, and ability to understand and remember God's stories is especially noticeable. Every week I teach these "Little Lambs" something new from the Bible. However, I'm quite certain that I am learning more from them. I know how deeply they have affected me over the years, and when one of them has to leave the class because a family is moving away, I am greatly affected by it. They are "my children," if only for an hour each Sunday morning. They are a dear and precious gift.

I am very grateful to God for answering my prayers for wisdom as a teacher. I thank the session for allowing me to teach. Mostly I am thankful to the parents of these little ones for sharing them with me, for the support that they show me, and for the trust they place in me to give their children their first Sunday School experience with lessons about the Lord. My hope is that each of them will someday know Him and develop a close, personal relationship with Him.

Fran Onofrio is the mother of Katherine and Kristina. She works at Racebrook School.

Thumbs Up

(continued from page 1)

of our neighbors. These concerns were not ignored—we withdrew our request and asked our architect to start all over again and develop the property "as of right." We honestly believe that we have taken quite seriously the concerns and values of our neighbors in several ways. We have (1) reduced by one-half our occupancy to what now amounts to a "chapel" design and (2) redirected the traffic flow after consultation with the city traffic planner to reduce traffic on Bradley Street. (We remain eager to work with our neighbors to make this a positive project for the neighborhood.) Meanwhile, we have tried to work with preservationists in order to maintain the integrity and historicity of the cottage. It has been our intention to move forward in good faith and in a way that is sensitive to the needs of both our city at large and our immediate neighbors.



The music team leads singing at a recent outreach service at Edgewood School.

Over the past several years, we have spent substantial sums of money and a lot of sweat equity restoring the existing historical building. Much work was done by the members of our church on a volunteer basis. We love the place. Moreover, we have spent additional funds preparing to develop our property with a facility that is consistent with the preservation of property and family values in the neighborhood and that complies with the

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zone ordinance. In response to the issues and values raised by our neighbors, Christ Presbyterian Church is most definitely a family friendly church that can respect their interest not only in preserving their hard-earned property values but also in keeping our neighborhood a safe and peaceful place to take a walk and park our cars. The kinds of programs that we would offer are demographically related to the interests of this neighborhood.

Finally, we would like to formally request public input for the "final site plan review" when we appear next before this commission in order to give our neighbors an

opportunity to express their views if needed. We have delivered this request in writing to the City Plan Commission. We have also communicated our willingness to happily meet with representatives from the neighborhood before we begin to draw up the final plans and submit them for final review. We honestly want to be good neighbors and will look forward to these meetings. We are, in summary, a congregation of one of the fastest growing denominations in North America, consisting of well over a quarter of a million people with churches in practically every major city. Our tradition dates back 350 years—and yet we are presently NOT represented in this city or even in the surrounding greater New Haven region. We love this city and aim to serve it. We have proceeded by the right of law, recognizing that without the law no one would have any confidence in entrepreneurial enterprise of any sort. We hope that the commission will appreciate not only what we have already done to restore one of New Haven's greatest historic treasures, as was recognized formally a year ago by the New Haven Preservationist Society in their annual meeting, but also what we plan to do by planting in New Haven a tradition that is presently not represented here that will bring with it valuable human resources. We thank you for your hard work on these matters and look forward to moving forward with you in this project.

Rev. Preston Graham, Jr. is the Pastor of Christ Presbyterian Church.

Building Plans

(continued from page 1)

Haven. For a couple of years I enjoyed living, working, and worshiping on the same block with zero commuting, and I did what I could for the church while we met at the Neighborhood Music School. The church was growing quickly and a vision for greater New Haven was upon the session when we began looking for a future home of our own. Well, as you know, God provided us the property at 135 Whitney at just the right time (when we could afford it!). Since then, I have for several years been developing ideas and sketches of what might be added to our wonderful “cottage” every Christmas break on my in-laws’ dining table in Seattle. We waited patiently for God’s timing and the official go-ahead while preparing as best we could for what we knew would be a tremendous undertaking for our congregation. Meanwhile, in 1997 a dear mentor and previous employer of mine called me and asked me to join him on an amazing project to be built on Long Island. After much prayer and discussion, I accepted his offer and moved in with my cousin in New York City. Each week I commuted back to New Haven on Fridays. This period of time was challenging to me personally as God helped me to address issues with my family in New York and also to learn and do new things vocationally. Mary Li was fulfilling her call at Yale and having a great impact on many when we discussed again possible changes that were on the horizon. Last year we decided to sell our condo in New Haven (our first home together) so that we could be open to whatever opportunities God might call us to. It was a summer and fall I will not forget: we sold our home, Mary Li accepted a job offer in New York City, we looked for and eventually found apartments there and New Haven, and my office moved to Long Island. The obvious question that everyone has asked is “Why are you keeping a second home in New Haven if you are both working in New York?” At the time we made the decision, with input from Preston, I felt a change of heart and believed it was

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best that we stay with CPC. Part of my decision was a belief that the building project would go ahead (the congregation voted late last year to move forward) and that the Lord had a part for me in it. I did not know then the twists and turns that would come in the next few months after I took a leave of absence in January to work full time on our church building project. I view my leave as a “vocational mission,” splitting my six-day work week between Oyster Bay, Long Island and Lincoln Street, New Haven. Now as I sit here humbly recounting God’s leading and provisions I can testify to his sovereignty and grace, which I could never have foreseen or imagined! Although I tend to be a “behind the scenes” type of person, the Lord has put me “front and center” in the lives of many people. My presence is a silent witness of my convictions and commitment to the Lord and His body, and I have

discovered a freedom to fellowship and witness in spite of my hectic and demanding schedule that has also invigorated my own walk. There is a sense of wonder and awe as I awake each day (no alarm clock—I awake as I need to) and watch as the day’s activi-

ties unfold before me. There is a feeling of adventure that I have not experienced since my early Christian conversion days in the ’80s when the youthful idealism and zeal had not yet given way to the routines and responsibilities of my thirties. As I approach my forties, I believe that I will see with CPC the mighty and merciful provisions of God as we grow spiritually and physically in our new home on Whitney Avenue. Great things will happen here for the glory of Christ: changed lives! I am honored and privileged to be a part of this work in a season for which God prepared me, and I want to thank all those who have prayed diligently and faithfully for CPC and the work that God has put before us. Great challenges and hurdles remain ahead, but I believe that it will only help our faith and add to His glory as we see His will prevail.

Dexter Chen is an architect and the husband of Mary Li Hsu.

Redemption

BY KATIE LEVESQUE



Readings

Have you ever wondered why God decided to send his son to die on the cross? Wasn’t there another way? *Redemption Accomplished and Applied* by John Murray addresses these questions and more. It may sound lofty and academic, but it’s really a very readable and encouraging book that talks about God’s work in history and in believers. The first half of the book is about “redemption accomplished,” meaning God’s work through Christ. Why was the atonement necessary? What was its nature? What did it accomplish? Murray answers these questions carefully, reminding the reader of God’s amazing work in history and stressing the

perfection of God’s plan. Christ’s death was sufficient—it fully paid for the sins of the elect. Yes, believers should respond to God with obedience because they are saved by grace, but they should rest on Christ’s work alone for their salvation. Freed from the burden of earning their righteousness before God, believers can focus on responding with thanks and doing God’s will. In the second half of the book, Murray explains “redemption applied”—how God works in the lives of the elect through the Holy Spirit. Stressing that the process of salvation is just beginning when a person professes faith and is justified, Murray discusses effectual calling, regeneration, repentance and faith, justification, adoption, sanctification, perseverance, union with Christ, and glorification. If you have ever wondered how God works throughout the different stages of the life of an elect individual, this book is for you. The Holy

Spirit works continually in the life of believers. We are always being sanctified and conformed to the image of Christ. On one of those days when you don’t feel assured that God is at work in your life, pick up this book and read the section on sanctification. It is an encouraging reminder that it is God who sanctifies and not we ourselves. Our job is to cooperate with the Spirit at work within us and recognize our dependence upon him. The doctrines of grace truly remind us of what a wonderful, powerful, and loving God we serve. Praise him for his work in Christ and thank him for his work in your own life! Murray’s book may be able to expand your understanding of the wonder of God’s plan of redemption.

Katie Levesque is an English teacher at Choate Rosemary Hall.

CPC Calendar

May

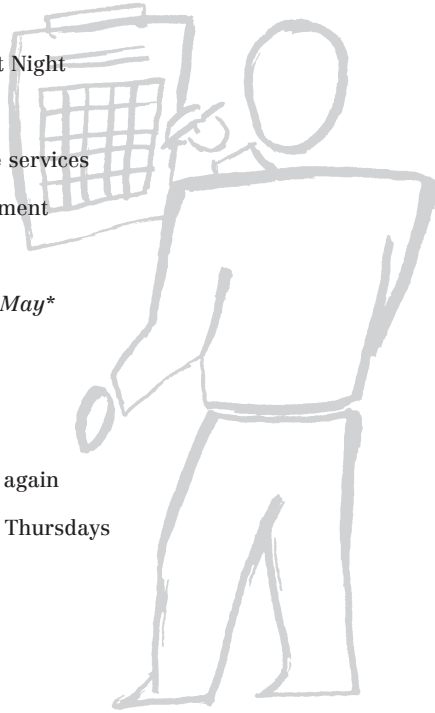
- 5 Women's Cookies and Craft Night
- 13 Study Center Work Day
- 21 Yale College Baccalaureate services
- 22 Yale University Commencement
- 27 Men's Prayer Breakfast

No School of Discovery during May

June

- 5 Women's Dessert
- 7 School of Discovery begins again

Watch for details about Terrific Thursdays this summer!



The kids enjoy lunch at Mt. Tenney on the family ski retreat in February.



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